

SECTION FIFTEEN

DESIGNING YOUR KEY LOCATIONS

You don't need to map every corner of your world. What you need are three to five carefully designed locations where the pivotal romantic moments happen, places that do actual narrative work.

A great romantasy location isn't just a pretty backdrop. It's a space with specific constraints that either force connection or make intimacy dangerous. The best locations have physical details that create story pressure: a narrow bridge where they must press close to pass, a garden where anyone might overhear, a cave where darkness strips away every defence they've built.

You've already built geography (Section 1), established how the natural world works (Section 2), and identified institutions that trap your characters (Section 14). Now you're going to design the specific locations where your romance actually unfolds. The rooms, gardens, battlefields, and hidden corners where the important moments happen.

The Stage Principle

Think of your key locations as stages, not backdrops.

Backdrops are wallpaper. Pretty, atmospheric, interchangeable. Stages have wings where characters enter and exit. Lighting that can change the mood. Props that the characters need to interact with. And an audience, or the very real possibility of one.

Every stage constrains what can happen on it. A narrow balcony brings people closer to each other. A large crowd in a ballroom makes even the most innocent-sounding conversation seem illicit. A battlefield demands cooperation before it permits tenderness. The space doesn't exist as a static background; it's an active participant shaping what your characters can do, say, and feel.

Key locations in romantasy should operate like a third character in the scene. They create pressure, they allow for moments that could never occur anywhere else, and they contain memories and meaning that deepen with every visit. When you design a key location, you're not simply decorating. You're engineering the conditions that make your pivotal romantic moments inevitable.

The parapet in *Fourth Wing* is a brilliant example of this. It's not just the point where Violet enters the riders' quadrant. It's a narrow walkway above a deadly drop with no railings, where a larger and stronger cadet can push you off the edge to your death. The space itself IS the stakes. The parapet creates proximity (everyone walks across the same narrow area), creates danger (one misstep and you're dead), and reveals character (who helps, who shoves, who freezes). Each time a scene occurs on the parapet, it's doing narrative work because the location was designed to create tension, not just look exciting.

Here's the test: if you can move a scene to any other location and nothing changes, the stage isn't working. But if the scene could only happen *here*, because of the privacy, the danger, the history, the physical constraints, then you've built a stage that earns its place in the story.

Pick one key scene you're already planning. Could you move it to a different location without losing anything?

This is the stage test. If nothing changes when you swap the location, the space is a backdrop, not a stage. If you answer "yes, it could happen anywhere," that's your signal to redesign the location or move the scene somewhere that earns it.

THE SCENE

Could it happen elsewhere without losing anything? If yes, what constraint, danger, or history could you add to make this location irreplaceable?

YOUR ANSWER

Locations and Romantic Pressure

Every location creates a specific kind of romantic pressure. Before you design your spaces, it helps to understand the five types of pressure a location can exert, and what each one gives your romance.

LOCATION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES FOR ROMANCE	EXAMPLES
Forces Connection	Narrow spaces, shared resources, dangerous surroundings, tasks requiring cooperation	Characters who wouldn't choose proximity are pushed together physically; resentment and attraction collide	One shelter in a storm; a narrow mountain path; a ritual requiring two participants
Enables Intimacy	Privacy, beauty, comfort, liminal spaces, neutral ground	Characters can finally drop defences, speak freely, or act on feelings they've been suppressing	A hidden garden; a space between worlds; a room neither of them owns
Creates Risk	Public-but-feels-private spaces, enemy territory, sacred spaces, watched spaces, time-limited encounters	Every touch, word, or glance carries the thrill of potential consequences; intimacy becomes transgression	A balcony during a ball; a meeting in enemy territory; a temple where desire is forbidden
Reveals Character	Home territory, workplaces, high-stress environments, places of comfort	Characters see each other in new contexts: competence, vulnerability, origin, truth	His childhood home; her command post; the place she goes when she's afraid
Active Magical Spaces	Sentient environments, emotion-responsive	The space itself strips away masks, compels honesty, or mandates	A house that senses trauma and adjusts; a corridor that induces

LOCATION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES FOR ROMANCE	EXAMPLES
	wards, truth-compelling features, shifting geography	proximity through magical mechanics; intimacy is enforced by the environment, not chosen by the characters	hidden desires; wards that tether bonded pairs

The strongest locations combine two or more types. A hidden cave during a blizzard forces connection (one shelter) AND enables intimacy (total privacy). An enemy court enables intimacy (they must pretend to be allies) AND creates risk (discovery means death).

Pairings and Location

Different relationship dynamics interact with locations differently. Have a think about what your pairing needs most:

PAIRING DYNAMIC	LOCATION THAT SERVES IT BEST	WHY IT WORKS
Enemies to lovers	Forced connection + risk	They need to be stuck together AND have stakes if feelings show
Forbidden love	Risk + enables intimacy	They need stolen moments where they can be real, shadowed by danger
Slow burn	Reveals character + enables intimacy	They need spaces that gradually peel back layers over time
Forced proximity	Forces connection + reveals character	The constraint is the point, but the revelation is what changes things
Second chance	Enables intimacy + history/memory	They need a space that echoes what they had and shows what's changed

PAIRING DYNAMIC	LOCATION THAT SERVES IT BEST	WHY IT WORKS
Fated mates / bonded pairs	Active magical spaces + forced connection	The magic of the space (or the bond) mandates proximity and emotional bleed; they can't run from what they feel

What is your pairing dynamic, and which one or two types of location pressure does it need most?

For example, enemies to lovers typically needs forced connection + risk. Refer to the tables above. You can combine more than one pressure type.

(Write your answer below)

Which of your planned locations already creates this pressure – and which ones don't?

Check your existing locations against the pressure type you identified above. If a location doesn't create the right kind of pressure for your pairing, it may need redesigning or a different scene.

YOUR ANSWER

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to every location. Some spaces are simple, some are complex. You might design one location in detail and sketch another in broad strokes. Use what serves your story and skip what doesn't!

Common Mistakes with Location Design

Mistake #1: The Anywhere Scene

A pivotal romantic moment, first kiss, major confession, breaking point, happens in a location that has no particular features, constraints, or significance. You could move it to any other room and nothing would change. You're wasting one of your most powerful tools. Location should be part of *why* the moment happens, not just where. A confession forced by a collapsing cave is more compelling than a confession that just happens to occur in one.

FIX

For every pivotal scene, ask yourself: "What about this specific space makes this moment possible, inevitable, or more meaningful?" If you can't answer that, redesign the location or move the scene somewhere that earns it. In *A Court of Mist and Fury*, the Starfall scene works because of the specific setting: the rooftop, the falling stars, the beauty that mirrors Feyre's emotional opening. Move it to a dining room and the magic dies.

Mistake #2: The Pretty Backdrop

The location is described beautifully, lush gardens, sweeping vistas, atmospheric ruins, but it doesn't *do* anything. It sets a mood without creating constraints, enabling specific actions, or carrying narrative weight. Atmosphere without function is decoration. Readers feel the difference between a garden that's beautiful and a garden where anyone might overhear, where a specific flower triggers a memory, where the locked gate means they can't leave until the guard changes.

FIX

After you've described any location, add at least one constraint (what the space forces or prevents) and one stake (what happens if they're discovered here, or what this place means to them). Beauty should be a bonus, not the whole job.

Mistake #3: The Same Room Twice

All key romantic moments happen in similar locations. Always private, always safe, always comfortable. Or always dangerous, always public, always high-stakes. The locations blur together because they all create the same type of pressure. Variety in location creates variety in romantic tension. If every intimate moment happens in private safety, you lose the electric thrill of stolen moments in dangerous spaces. If every moment is high-stakes, you never get the tenderness of characters who can finally relax. **Quick check:**

Are any of your planned scenes falling into these traps? *Be honest: most first drafts have at least one “anywhere scene.” Catching it now saves a rewrite later.* Any scenes that could happen anywhere? Which one, and how could you anchor it? _____

Any locations that are pretty but don’t *do* anything? What constraint or stake could you add? _____

Are several of your locations creating the same type of pressure? Which one could you change for more contrast? _____

FIX

Check your key locations against the five pressure types (forces connection, enables intimacy, creates risk, reveals character, active magical spaces). Make sure you have a mix. If three of your five locations are “private and safe”, change one to “public and risky.”

Identifying Your Pivotal Moments

Before designing locations, identify the moments that need them. These are the scenes your readers will remember, the ones that deserve a stage built specifically for them.

List three to five major romantic moments in your story. Think about the moments that shift the relationship: where walls come down, where stakes become real, where everything changes.

List three to five pivotal romantic moments in your story – the scenes that shift the relationship, where walls come down, stakes become real, or everything changes.

(Write your answer below)

Matching Moments to Locations

For each moment: does this scene need a specific location, or could it happen anywhere? If it could happen anywhere, you've got a location problem. The best scenes are shaped by where they happen.

The "Why It Must Happen There" column is the most important one. If you can't fill it in, the location isn't doing enough work.

MOMENT	HAPPENS IN	WHY IT MUST HAPPEN THERE
First real conversation <i>(example)</i>	The palace's hidden library	Only place in court without magical surveillance; both discovered it separately while hiding secrets

MOMENT	HAPPENS IN	WHY IT MUST HAPPEN THERE
First kiss (<i>example</i>)	The cliffside ruins at sunset	Ancient warding stones block tracking magic; surrounded by deadly drop that makes rescue impossible if discovered
Moment 1		
Moment 2		
Moment 3		
Moment 4		

MOMENT	HAPPENS IN	WHY IT MUST HAPPEN THERE
Moment 5		

Designing Your Key Locations

Use the following framework for each key location. Not every question will matter for every space, so focus on the ones that create the most pressure for your specific scene.

Location: _____

The Physical Space and Sensory World

The things your characters experience with their senses at a particular location aren't decoration. Those experiences constitute the fabric of intimacy. What your characters see, hear, smell, and feel in a space shapes what's possible between them. Firelight creates different possibilities than fluorescent light. Silence invites confession; noise requires closeness to be heard. Cold drives bodies together, and heat makes skin aware of skin.

A good location will create both a need for a certain type of intimacy and also prevent another from occurring. A narrow bridge forces physical closeness but prevents private conversation if others are crossing. On the other hand, a soundproof room enables emotional honesty but removes the ability for either character to use "we might be overheard" as an excuse for avoiding hard truths.

Describe the location in 2-3 sentences. What's the dominant impression?

First impressions matter. The dominant impression of a space (cramped, exposed, warm, hostile) sets the emotional baseline for every scene that happens here. Get this right and the reader will feel the location before they understand it.

(Think: size, lighting, temperature, sounds, smells, textures)

YOUR ANSWER

What sensory details would your characters notice most?

WHAT THEY SEE

WHAT THEY HEAR

WHAT THEY SMELL

WHAT THEY FEEL (TEMPERATURE, TEXTURE, AIR)

How big is this location, and how long does it take to cross?

Scale shapes everything. A location you can cross in thirty seconds creates different tension than one that takes an hour to traverse. A single room forces intimacy; a sprawling estate lets characters avoid each other – or seek each other out.

YOUR ANSWER

Who lives or works here? Where within this location do people actually sleep, eat, and gather?

Knowing where everyday life happens tells you where characters will run into each other – and where they can hide. A barracks with shared sleeping quarters creates very different possibilities than a palace with private wings.

YOUR ANSWER

What threats or dangers exist at this location?

Think beyond dramatic combat. Dangerous wildlife, unstable structures, poisonous plants, treacherous weather, hostile locals, magical hazards. Everyday dangers shape how characters move through a space and what risks they take to be together.

YOUR ANSWER

How do people get to this location from the nearest settlement or key location?

A location that takes three days on horseback through hostile territory creates very different story possibilities than one connected by a busy road. The journey to a location is often where anticipation builds.

YOUR ANSWER

What does this space force characters to do? What does it prevent them from doing?

Think about physical proximity, cooperation, vulnerability on the “force” side – and escape, privacy, honesty on the “prevent” side. The best locations do both at once.

(Write your answer below)

What features define the space?

These physical features aren't just setting details; they're the mechanics of your romantic scene. Exits determine whether characters can flee; barriers determine what they can see and hide; dangerous elements determine whether proximity is a choice or a necessity.

SIZE/LAYOUT

EXITS/ENTRANCES

BARRIERS/OBSTACLES

DANGEROUS ELEMENTS

What makes this location difficult to reach or leave?

Difficulty of access is one of your strongest tools for forced proximity. If they can't easily leave, they must stay and face whatever happens between them. If they can't easily arrive, the effort of getting here raises the stakes of what happens once they do.

YOUR ANSWER

What makes this location immediately distinct from your other key locations?

Every location needs a signature – the constant wind, the smell of sulfur, the way sound echoes, the colour of the stone. If a reader couldn't tell your locations apart from a single sensory detail, they may be too similar.

YOUR ANSWER

Ultimately, the amount of privacy in a specific location will affect the type of romantic tension created by that location. In a totally private setting, a couple has the opportunity to be vulnerable, but this takes away the thrill of transgressing boundaries. Total exposure makes every glance electric but prevents real honesty. Many romantasy scenes take place in semi-private settings. Private enough to be real, risky enough to be dangerous.

How private is this location?

- ☐ Completely private: no chance of interruption
- ☐ Semi-private: could be interrupted but unlikely
- ☐ Risky: interruption is possible at any moment
- ☐ Public: others are present or could arrive

Why is this level of privacy right for the moment that happens here?

Total privacy enables vulnerability but removes transgression. Total exposure makes every glance electric but prevents honesty. What does your scene need?

YOUR ANSWER

Who else could be here? Who has access?

Knowing who might walk in, and what they'd think, defines the stakes of every private moment. A space where a rival could appear creates different tension than one where a mentor might arrive.

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if they were discovered here together?

Be specific. Not just "scandal," but actual consequences. Exile? Broken alliance? A forced marriage to someone else? The price of intimacy in this space is what makes stolen moments electric.

YOUR ANSWER

Can they see or hear someone approaching, or could they be surprised?

A warning of interruption creates delicious tension; they know the clock is ticking. Surprise interruption creates crisis. Which serves your scene better?

YOUR ANSWER



What can happen here that couldn't happen elsewhere?

This is the ultimate test of whether your location earns its place. If the answer is “nothing specific,” the stage isn't working yet. Go back and add a constraint, a danger, or a history that makes this space irreplaceable.

YOUR ANSWER

What comfort, safety, or resource does this location provide?

Even dangerous locations usually offer something: shelter, warmth, food, silence. That offering shapes what kind of intimacy becomes possible. Characters who are cold huddle together. Characters who are fed can finally talk. Characters who feel safe can finally feel.

YOUR ANSWER

What kinds of closeness does this space make possible?

Physical (can they touch, stand close, be comfortable):

YOUR ANSWER

Emotional (can they speak freely, show vulnerability):

YOUR ANSWER

What kinds of closeness are impossible here – and why?

The gap between what the space allows and what it prevents is where romantic tension lives. A space that allows physical closeness but prevents honest conversation creates a very different scene than one that does the opposite.

YOUR ANSWER

What do they want that this location won't allow?

Unmet desire is the engine of romantic tension. If the space prevents what they want most (privacy, touch, honesty, escape), that gap between wanting and having is where your best scenes live.

YOUR ANSWER



Time, Atmosphere and Weather

Locations are fluid. Time and weather alter them as well as the possibilities they create. A garden at noon is exposed; at midnight, it's a different world entirely. Rain forces characters under the same shelter. Snow isolates. Fog hides. The same location can serve entirely different scenes depending on when your characters arrive.

Time of day also shapes the *type* of romantic tension a space creates. At dawn, there's a sense of vulnerability because both partners were awake all night and the defences each has erected throughout the day have been lowered, and the coming daylight forces a reckoning with what happened in the dark. Midday is exposure, public, nowhere to hide. Dusk is transition, the moment the public person begins to shed their skin to become the private one, the moment the rules of the day start loosening. And midnight is transgression. Nothing good and proper happens at midnight, which is exactly why the best scenes do.

How does this location change at different times?

The same space creates completely different romantic tension depending on when your characters arrive.

Think about which version serves your scene best.

What time of day does your pivotal scene happen here, and how does the space look and feel at that hour?

Timing should feel deliberate – chosen because this version of the space creates the right pressure. Dawn lowers defences. Midday exposes. Dusk loosens rules. Midnight invites transgression.

(Write your answer below)

Why is this the right time for what happens between your characters?

WHY IS THIS THE RIGHT TIME FOR WHAT HAPPENS BETWEEN YOUR CHARACTERS?

How does weather change what's possible in this space?

Rain forces characters under the same shelter. Snow isolates. Fog hides. Wind makes whispered conversation impossible unless they lean close. Think about whether weather plays a role in the scene that happens here.

YOUR ANSWER

How does this location change across seasons?

A frozen lake is a road in winter and a barrier in summer. A garden is lush in spring and skeletal in autumn. If your story spans time, the season shapes what the location offers and what it denies.

YOUR ANSWER

History, Memory and Meaning

A location with history has gravity. Even though readers may have no knowledge about all the historical events that occurred at a specific location, they'll be aware of the feeling of history. A battlefield where thousands died carries different energy than a newly built room. Each time a character interacts in a space where they've previously experienced trauma, it's going to reshape every interaction that happens there.

Locations can be personable too. The best ones give off the feeling that they're alive, not just as settings but as presences that affect the characters. A house that feels welcoming or hostile. A forest that seems to guide them somewhere. A room that holds secrets.

(Reference Section 7 for your world's history)

What happened in this place before your characters arrive?

Past events leave residue, emotional, magical, or both. A location where a famous love story ended in tragedy mirrors (or threatens) the current romance. History gives a space gravity that pure description can't.

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters know the history of this place?

Knowledge of the past changes how a character experiences a space. A character who knows this was a massacre site inhabits a completely different scene than one who sees only a pretty meadow, and that asymmetry creates tension.

YOUR ANSWER

Does this location have personal significance to either character?

A place from their past, a meaningful memory, somewhere they've been before. Personal history adds private weight to shared space, and discovering that weight is often a turning point for the other character.

YOUR ANSWER



Does this location feel like it has a will of its own?

A house that feels welcoming or hostile, a forest that seems to lead them somewhere, a room that holds secrets. Even non-magical locations can feel alive to the characters moving through them.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the location seem to respond to the characters?

Does it help them – convenient shelter, paths that lead where they need? Resist them – doors that stick, paths that mislead? Reveal things to them – hidden rooms, unexpected views? Think about whether the space feels cooperative, obstructive, or indifferent.

YOUR ANSWER

If this location were a character, what would its personality be?

Protective, threatening, indifferent, playful, melancholy, ancient, patient? A location's "personality" shapes how characters feel within it – and a space that feels hostile creates very different scenes than one that feels welcoming.

YOUR ANSWER



What the Reader Knows

Some of the most electrifying romantic moments happen when the reader knows something about a location that one or both characters don't. This is spatial dramatic irony, and romantasy absolutely thrives on it.

When the reader finds out that Velaris is a hidden paradise before Feyre understands what it means about Rhysand's character, the entire Night Court is operating under a geographic deception; what looks like a kingdom of cruelty is actually a shield protecting a city of starlight. Every scene where Feyre fears Rhysand is charged with the reader's knowledge that he's been protecting something beautiful. In *Fourth Wing*, Xaden knows the truth about Aretia and the venom while Violet navigates Basgiath believing official history. His inability to share the map creates a wall she reads as a lack of trust, when it's actually the opposite.

Spatial irony gives the reader a sense of being complicit. When we know the secret of a location before the protagonist does, we inhabit the same lonely space as the love interest who's keeping that secret. We watch the protagonist misread the geography and ache for the moment of unveiling, which is almost always the moment the romance breaks through.

Does the reader know something about this location that one or both characters don't?

Spatial dramatic irony, where the reader knows a location's secret before the characters do, creates complicity between the reader and whoever holds the secret. It's one of the most powerful tools for making readers ache for the reveal.

YOUR ANSWER

Does one character know something about this space that the other doesn't?

Knowledge asymmetry turns a location into an emotional minefield. The character who knows this was a massacre site, or that the room is being watched, carries weight the other can't see, and that invisible weight shapes every interaction.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your story have a “geographic lie” – a place that isn’t what characters believe it to be?

A place presented as safe that’s actually compromised, a place feared that’s actually sanctuary, a place believed destroyed that still exists. Geographic lies create powerful tension because revealing the truth about a place is an act of trust.

YOUR ANSWER

Magical Properties

(Skip if this location has no magical features. Reference Section 10 for your magic system.)

Some of the most compelling romantasy locations aren't just physical spaces. These settings are often "alive" with magic, responding to, constraining, or transforming the characters within them. In ACOTAR, the House of Wind is aware of Nesta's traumatic fear of fire, so it warms the floors instead of lighting a hearth. The wards in *Fourth Wing* physically bind bonded riders to each other's proximity. The Sin Corridor in *Kingdoms of the Wicked* has the ability to elicit specific emotions from every person that passes through it, bypassing conscious defences entirely.

Why do magical location properties matter for romance? Because they can accomplish things that real-world locations can't: strip away masks, force emotional transparency, mandate proximity through metaphysical bonds, or create sanctuary so complete that even traumatised characters can begin to feel safe. They're not just cool worldbuilding details. They're mechanical tools that enable the intimate moments your story needs.

Does this location have active magical properties – wards, enchantments, sentience, shifting geography, emotion-responsiveness, truth-compelling features, magical barriers?

What magical properties does this location have, and how do they affect the characters?

Consider wards, sentience, emotional influence, shifting geography, bonding or tethering magic. For each that applies, describe how the magic works here.

(Write your answer below)

Does the magic here bypass your characters' defences?

Emotion-responsive environments, truth-compelling pools, sin-testing corridors – these spaces force a transparency that characters would never choose voluntarily. If your location has this property, it can accelerate intimacy in a way that feels earned because the space is doing the work, not a convenient change of heart.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the magic here create safety, danger, or both?

The best magical locations offer something your characters desperately need while simultaneously taking something away. The House of Wind provides sanctuary but also isolation. The wards of Navarre protect but also trap.

YOUR ANSWER

How might this location's magical properties change over the course of the story?

Wards that weaken, sentient spaces that grow hostile, enchantments that fade or intensify. Shifting magical properties can mirror the shifting relationship.

YOUR ANSWER

The Moment

What pivotal moment happens at this location?

Name the scene – first kiss, major confession, betrayal, breaking point, reunion. Be specific about what shifts between the characters.

YOUR ANSWER

Why can this moment only happen here?

This is the ultimate test of your location design. What about this specific space – its constraints, its danger, its history, its privacy – makes this moment possible, inevitable, or more meaningful? If you can't answer this, the location needs more work.

YOUR ANSWER

Writing Location into Your Scenes

You've designed the location. Now you have to get it onto the page without killing the pacing. This is where many writers stumble. They've done the worldbuilding work, they're excited about their atmospheric ruin or enchanted forest, and they feel compelled to front-load three paragraphs of description before anything actually happens. The romantic tension evaporates. The reader skims.

The golden rule of romantasy setting is this: **reveal the location through your character's body, not through a camera.** Don't describe the room. Describe what your character feels, fears, notices, and bumps into while they're in the room. The reader builds the picture from those fragments, and the picture is richer because it's filtered through emotion.

Many successful romantasy authors treat setting as an obstacle that characters move *through*, not something they stand in front of and observe. When we read the opening of ACOTAR, we don't see a description of the economic structure of Feyre's village. We're shown Feyre hunting in a frozen forest, overpaying for pelts, and fearing faeries near the wall. Three pieces of worldbuilding revealed through action. In *Fourth Wing*, the reader doesn't see a description of the parapet from a distance; instead they experience it through Violet's huffing breath, the way she keeps herself mentally focused through reciting facts, and the scream of a cadet falling off the edge. The reader never receives a "description" of the parapet. They get the sense of crossing it.

This technique works through the use of the "dialogue beat", short physical actions that occur during dialogue or inner monologue that anchor the character in the space. If a character is shivering, you know the climate. If a character's boots slip, you know the surface. By repeating a particular scent (Armentrout uses "pine and sage" for Hawke throughout *From Blood and Ash*), you can establish the physical presence of the love interest in the world without writing a single descriptive paragraph.

Information Density

A good single sensory beat should be able to tell us about the setting, give us insight into a character's personality, and convey the emotional tone of the moment. A character pressing her back against a cold stone wall tells you the architecture (stone, cold), her tactical instinct (she wants something solid behind her), and her emotional state (she doesn't trust the room, or the person in it). That's three pieces of information in one action, and the pace never stalls.

In romantasy, less is almost always more when it comes to pure description. The reader's imagination will fill gaps you leave, but it can't recover momentum you've killed. A useful guideline: **no more than two to three sentences of pure description before something happens.** After that, setting details should be woven into action, dialogue, or internal thought.

For your pivotal romantic scenes specifically, be sure to include the one or two sensory details that matter most for the emotional beat (the firelight, the silence, the scent of rain), then let the rest emerge as the characters interact with the space. Your reader doesn't need to see the whole room before the scene starts. They need to

What are the one or two sensory details that matter most for this scene's emotional beat?

Not the whole room, just the details that carry emotional weight. The firelight, the silence, the scent of rain. These are your anchors. Everything else can emerge as the characters move through the space.

YOUR ANSWER

What dialogue beat could anchor your character in this space?

A dialogue beat is a short physical action during dialogue or inner monologue that tells the reader about the setting without stopping the scene for description. Shivering tells us the climate. Boots slipping tells us the surface. A repeated scent tells us the love interest is near. What's the beat that grounds your character here?

YOUR ANSWER

Locations That Return

Some places are repeated throughout a story, and each time the area is revisited, it should feel different because the characters and relationship have changed. An area that was intimidating as adversaries should feel safe and comfortable as allies, and this contrast tells the reader how much the characters have progressed.

This is one of the most powerful tools in romantasy. Consider how Feyre experiences the Night Court townhouse across the ACOTAR series. At first, it feels foreign and uncomfortable, but over the course of the books it gradually becomes home. And the shift isn't because the house changes. It's because Feyre does. Her comfort in the space, her ease with the people in it, her sense of belonging; all of that is tracked through how she moves through and relates to the same physical location. The townhouse becomes a barometer for the relationship.

Designing a Recurring Location

If characters return to a location, what changes between visits? Track how the same space reflects the evolving relationship. This is one of the most powerful tools you have.

VISIT	RELATIONSHIP STATE	WHAT'S DIFFERENT
First visit (<i>example</i>)	Enemies forced together	She keeps her back to the wall; he stays near the exit; they speak in clipped, formal sentences
Final visit (<i>example</i>)	Committed partners	They move around each other naturally; she sits in his chair; the space feels like theirs now
First visit		

VISIT	RELATIONSHIP STATE	WHAT'S DIFFERENT
Second visit		
Third visit		
Final visit		

What do they notice on return that they missed before?

Returning characters see spaces differently because they've changed. A detail that meant nothing on the first visit – a second chair, a view of the sunrise, the way sound carries – suddenly matters. These shifts tell the reader the relationship has moved without a word of exposition.

YOUR ANSWER

How does their behaviour in this space change between visits?

Physical behaviour in a shared space is one of the clearest ways to show relationship progression without a single word of dialogue. Where they stand, how close they get, what they're comfortable doing – track these shifts and the reader will feel the relationship evolving.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the location itself change, or only their perception of it?

Physical changes (seasons, damage, decay, growth) tell a story about the world. Perceptual changes, where the space feels different only because the characters have changed, tell a story about the relationship. The most powerful recurring locations use both.

YOUR ANSWER



“Their” Place

Some characters develop a location that becomes exclusively theirs. A spot they can go back to time after time, where significant moments keep happening. This is enormously powerful in romantasy because it gives the relationship a physical anchor in the world. Consider the rooftop during Starfall in ACOTAR. That space becomes Feyre and Rhys’s through the weight of what happens there. We don’t see them claim it through declaration; it grows on the reader through repetition and significance until the reader feels it belongs to them too.

Do your characters have a location that becomes specifically theirs?

A place they return to, where significant moments keep happening:

YOUR ANSWER

How does it become theirs?

Through repetition? A significant first moment? A private ritual they develop? The best “their place” locations aren’t claimed by declaration – they accumulate meaning through what happens there.

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean to lose access to this place?

If losing a location wouldn’t hurt, it’s not doing enough emotional work. The potential loss of “their place” should feel like losing a piece of the relationship itself.

YOUR ANSWER

Lost Locations

Some significant places are lost. Destroyed, changed, or closed forever. Because losing a meaningful location represents opportunity lost, the loss carries great significance.

Is there a location that becomes inaccessible to your characters?

Destroyed, transformed, forbidden, too dangerous, claimed by enemies, sealed by magic? Lost locations carry enormous emotional weight because they represent possibility that's gone.

YOUR ANSWER

What did this location mean to them?

What happened there? What did it represent? What possibility did it hold? The weight of a lost location comes from what it meant, not just what it was.

YOUR ANSWER

How does losing this place affect them?

Grief, loss of sanctuary, loss of possibility, motivation for action? The loss of a meaningful place can drive a character forward or hold them back.

YOUR ANSWER

What do they wish they'd done there – but now can't?

A conversation never had, a moment never taken, a chance lost. Regret tied to a specific place is one of the most powerful emotional anchors in a story.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the lost location exist only in memory by the end?

A place that lives on only in memory becomes a different kind of location – one that can never change, only be reinterpreted. This can be a source of comfort or pain.

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-Location Connections

The transition from one significant location to another is often where the most charged moments happen. The walk from the ballroom to the garden is where hands almost touch. The journey from the city to the wilderness is where the masks of civilisation start slipping. The climb from the base of the tower to the top is where the silence between them says everything. Don't skip transitions just because "nothing happens". The transition between locations is where anticipation builds, where characters are between roles, where the rules of one space have ended but the rules of the next haven't started yet.

What does the landscape look like between your key locations?

Readers need to feel the world between destinations – not just the destinations themselves. Dense forest, open plains, crowded streets, underground tunnels? The terrain between locations shapes travel time, danger, and how exposed or hidden characters are on the journey.

YOUR ANSWER

How do your locations physically connect to each other – roads, paths, waterways, portals?

The route between locations matters as much as the locations themselves. A single narrow road means characters can be tracked or ambushed. A secret tunnel means they can meet unseen. A river means they share a boat. The connection shapes the story.

YOUR ANSWER

Pick one transition between two of your key locations. What happens emotionally during the journey?

The space between locations is where characters are between roles. The rules of one space have ended but the rules of the next haven't started yet. This liminal zone is where hands almost touch, where silence says everything, where masks start slipping. Don't skip it.

YOUR ANSWER

Variety Check

Do your key locations feel different from each other?

Look at your key locations. Do you have a mix of:

- ☐ Public vs. private
- ☐ Dangerous vs. safe
- ☐ Forced proximity vs. chosen meeting
- ☐ Beautiful vs. harsh
- ☐ Familiar vs. unknown
- ☐ Their territory vs. neutral ground vs. enemy territory

If several of your locations feel similar, what could you change about one to create more contrast?

IF SEVERAL OF YOUR LOCATIONS FEEL SIMILAR, WHAT COULD YOU CHANGE ABOUT ONE TO CREATE MORE CONTRAST?

What one detail makes each key location instantly recognisable?

Every location needs a signature – something a reader could identify in a single sentence. The constant wind, the smell of sulfur, the way sound echoes. If you can't name it, the location may not be distinct enough yet.

YOUR ANSWER

Movement Between Locations

How do your characters travel between key locations – and do they travel together or apart?

A shared journey builds anticipation. Arriving separately creates the electric moment of seeing each other in a new context. Think about the mode of travel too: horseback, carriage, on foot, by portal. Each shapes the journey differently.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens between your characters during the journey from one key location to the next?

Transitions aren't dead space. They're the moments where the rules of one space have ended and the rules of the next haven't started yet. Characters are between roles, and that's when the most honest moments slip through.

YOUR ANSWER

The Arc of Locations

How do your locations progress through the story?

Do they move from public to private? Safe to dangerous? Familiar to unknown? Constraint to freedom? The arc of locations should mirror the arc of the relationship.

BEGINNING LOCATIONS

MIDDLE LOCATIONS

CLIMAX LOCATION

RESOLUTION LOCATION

The Final Location

Your romantic climax location is probably the most important location you'll choose in your entire novel. This is where everything converges: the moment of greatest emotional vulnerability, the final confession, the decisive choice. A well-chosen final location should tie in with events that occurred at prior locations while offering something new. They reward readers who've been paying attention to the geography of the relationship.

Where does the romantic climax happen?

The moment of greatest emotional vulnerability, final confession, or decisive choice:

YOUR ANSWER

Why is this the right place for this moment?

Does it echo earlier locations? Represent how far they've come? Offer something they've never had before? Force a final confrontation they've been avoiding?

YOUR ANSWER

How is this location different from where they started?

The contrast between the first significant location and the last tells readers the story of the relationship in spatial terms. If they started in a public court and end in a private room, that's a story about finding intimacy. If they started in safety and end on a battlefield, that's a story about what they're willing to risk.

YOUR ANSWER

The Location Test

A well-designed location does at least two of these:

- ☐ Forces physical proximity (must stand close, touch, share space)
- ☐ Creates danger requiring cooperation (must work together to survive)
- ☐ Provides privacy for vulnerability (can finally speak freely)
- ☐ Makes intimacy risky (discovery would have consequences)
- ☐ Offers something one character needs (forcing them into the other's domain)
- ☐ Mirrors emotional state (space reflects their bond)
- ☐ Changes meaning as the relationship evolves (same place, different significance)
- ☐ Has history that resonates (past events echo in the present moment)

For each of your key locations, check at least two boxes. If a location doesn't manage at least two, revise it: add a constraint, raise the stakes, build in history, adjust the symbolism.

Integration Check

Your key locations don't exist in isolation. They're shaped by every system you've built. Use this table to check that your locations are grounded in your world.

SYSTEM	CONNECTION TO YOUR LOCATIONS	EXAMPLE
Geography (Section 1)	How do terrain, climate, and natural features shape the physical constraints of each space?	A mountain pass location is narrow and exposed because of the geography, forcing proximity AND creating risk of being seen from above
Flora and Fauna (Section 2)	Do plants, creatures, or natural elements create atmosphere, danger, or sensory detail?	Bioluminescent moss in a cave provides the only light; intimate and otherworldly

SYSTEM	CONNECTION TO YOUR LOCATIONS	EXAMPLE
Culture (Section 3)	What cultural significance do locations carry: sacred sites, forbidden zones, traditional gathering places?	A location that's culturally forbidden adds transgression to any scene set there
History (Section 7)	What historical weight do locations hold: battlefields, ruins, sites of tragedy or triumph?	A ruin where a famous love story ended in tragedy mirrors (or threatens) the current romance
Technology (Section 9)	How do lighting, heating, construction, and tools shape what's possible?	No magical lighting means firelight only, which means closeness, shadows, intimacy
Institutions (Section 14)	Do locations exist within institutional spaces: academies, courts, military camps?	A stolen moment in a corner of the academy carries institutional risk: expulsion, punishment, scandal

Locations that are grounded in your existing world feel real, and real places create more powerful romantic moments than invented-on-the-spot ones. These connections also ensure your locations don't contradict what you've already established.

How do terrain, climate, and natural features shape your key locations (Section 1)?

Think about how the physical geography constrains or enables what happens in each space – a mountain pass is narrow and exposed, a coastal cave floods at high tide.

YOUR ANSWER

What plants, creatures, or natural elements appear at your locations (Section 2)?

Flora and fauna create atmosphere, danger, and sensory detail. Bioluminescent moss provides eerie light. Predators limit when characters can travel. Medicinal herbs give a reason to visit.

YOUR ANSWER

What cultural meaning do any of your locations carry (Section 3)?

Sacred sites, forbidden zones, traditional gathering places – cultural significance adds weight to any scene set there, especially if characters are breaking taboos.

YOUR ANSWER

What historical events happened at or near your locations (Section 7)?

Battlefields, ruins, sites of tragedy or triumph. Historical weight gives a location gravity that pure description can't.

YOUR ANSWER

How do your world's technology and infrastructure shape these spaces (Section 9)?

Lighting, heating, construction, and tools shape what's possible. No magical lighting means firelight only – which means closeness, shadows, and intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER

Do any of your locations sit within institutional spaces (Section 14)?

Academies, courts, military camps, temples. Institutional locations carry built-in rules and consequences – a stolen moment in the academy risks expulsion, not just embarrassment.

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Your Key Locations

List your three most important locations: the place that becomes “theirs,” any location that is lost or becomes inaccessible, and the location where the romantic climax happens.

(Write your answer below)

Final Thought

Every key location should be doing narrative work in its own right. It's not just where something happens. It's part of *why* it happens.

The space should constrain, enable, reveal, or transform. It should make moments possible that couldn't happen elsewhere, or make possible moments dangerous in ways they wouldn't be elsewhere.

Design places that readers will remember because the space itself was part of the story. Romantic moments don't just happen in locations. They happen *because* of them.